Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A K 3 ♥ K 8 6 5 ♦ 9 7 6 2 ♣ A J	
♠ 8 7 6 2 ♥ J ♦ A K J 8 ♣ 7 6 4 2	N W E S	♠ Q J 10 4 ♥ Q 10 9 3 ♦ Q 10 4 3 ♣ 5
	♠ 9 5 ♥ A 7 4 2 ♦ 5 ♣ K Q 10 9 8 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♠Q

It is tempting to bid 3NT and hope partner can use your ♣ suit. But you have something very important in your hand - a 4-card ♥ suit.

So you bid 2♣. (Stayman, not your ♣ suit!) Partner replies 2♥. What do you say next?

He who knows, goes. You have 11 points and 4 ♥s. Partner has at least 15 points and 4 ♥s. So you bid the game.

South would play 4♥.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♠Q.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♠Q.

Losers: ♠ 0 : ♥ 1 or 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 0 : Total = 2 or 3

This PLAN looks awfully simple. Win the ♠, play ♥A, ♥K, then give up a ♥. When you get back in run the ♣s.

But when you play the second high ♥ West shows out.

Make another Plan, then

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♠Q.

Let's start over. Play ♥K, then ♥A. West shows out. If you play another ♥ East will pull all the trumps and they will start winning ♦ tricks. Lots of ♦ tricks.

So don't lead the third ♥. Leave East with his two master trumps and start playing ♣ winners. East will eventually ruff in with one of his high trumps and perhaps take a ♦ trick. But you have trump control and can get in again and reach dummy with a ruff to continue ♣s. All East can do is get his one more trump.

When you have pulled a couple of rounds of trumps and the defenders hold a master trump it is usually good technique to leave it out. No sense using two of yours to get one of theirs.

This hand is much rarer - leaving TWO master trumps out. But you can see that it is the correct technique.

Board 2
East Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 7 6 3 ♥ 8 4 ♦ J 7 6 ♣ A 9 6 4	
♠ 10 4 ♥ K J 7 5 2 ♦ 10 8 3 ♣ 8 5 3	N W E S	♠ Q J 9 8 ♥ Q 10 3 ♦ A 9 4 2 ♣ 10 7
	♠ K 5 2 ♥ A 9 6 ♦ K Q 5 ♣ K Q J 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		Pass	1♣
Pass	1♠	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♥5

the ♥Q.

This sure looks like an opening 1NT hand, except for one little thing - it is too strong. Make sure you open 1NT **ONLY** with hands containing 15-17 points. For this one you open 1♣. Partner responds 1♠.

Do not support partner's Major suit response with only 3 cards. It is good to raise partner's Major suit **OPENING** with 3 trumps because he guarantees a 5-card suit. As a **RESPONSE** he only promises a 4-card suit, so you should have 4 in the suit to give immediate support.

In fact you have a perfect bid. With a balanced hand and 18-19 points you open 1 of a suit, then jump in Notrump. Holding 18 points you bid 2NT and partner raises to 3NT.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥5. East plays the ♥Q.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥5. East plays

Winner count: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 4 : Total = 7

You need 2 more winners and they will come from the ♦ suit once you have forced out the ♦A. There is a problem though. When the opponents get the lead with the ♦A they might cash 4 ♥ tricks. Of course if it is East who wins the ♦A and if he doesn't have a ♥ to play then all will be well. So you don't take your ♥A on the first trick, nor do you take it on the second trick. At trick 3 you have no choice so you win your ♥A.

Now you can take your 4 ♣ tricks if you like. Then lead a ♦ honor. If they don't take their ♦A on this trick you play another ♦ honor. One of the defenders will win this trick. If it is East you will make your contract, if it is West you will go down.

Visualize what would happen if you played the ♥A on the first or second trick. When you tried to establish ♦ tricks East would take the ♦A and play a ♥ to West and you would go down 1. By waiting until the third round to take the ♥A you exhaust East of his ♥s.

Notice that if West was the one who had the ♦A then you would go down despite your hold-up play. This PLAN is not a guarantee - but if you follow it you will make the contract 50% of the time. If you don't follow it you will make the contract 0% of the time.

Board 3
West Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ 3 ♥ A K Q J 8 3 ♦ 8 6 3 ♣ 9 6 3	
♠ K 8 6 5 ♥ 9 ♦ K Q J 4 ♣ K J 10 7	N W E S	♠ 10 9 7 4 ♥ 6 5 ♦ A 7 5 2 ♣ 8 5 2
	♠ A Q J 2 ♥ 10 7 4 2 ♦ 10 9 ♣ A Q 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♦	1♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♦A

With 12 points and an excellent suit you overcall 1♥.

Partner raises to 4♥ and everyone passes.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♦A and the defense wins two high ♦s then switches to a trump.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♦A and the defense wins two high ♦s then switches to a trump.

Losers: ♠ 0 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 2 : Total = 4

The two ♦ losers are already lost, so you must eliminate a ♣ loser. If East has the ♣K then a simple finesse will win the day. That would be a 50% chance, right? **WRONG!** That would be a 0% chance. You and partner hold 23 HCP. East has already produced 4 HCP with the ♦A, and if he had 3 more that would mean West opened with only 10 points. Very doubtful.

So face it, West has the ♣K.

However, dummy has some nice ♠ cards. So you pull the last trump, play your ♠3 to dummy's ♠A, then lead the ♠Q. If West puts on his ♠K (which you know he must have) you ruff it. Then enter dummy with a ♦ ruff and discard the small ♣ on the good ♠J. If West doesn't play his ♠K you discard your ♣ loser immediately.

If you separate the bidding from the play in your mind you will too often miss clues that should be telling you that certain plans will or won't work.

This was a perfect example. After the opening lead it was easy to deduce that all the rest of the high cards had to be in the West hand.

Board 4
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 9 8 5 ♥ Q ♦ A 7 6 4 3 ♣ A 10 9 2	
♠ J 3 ♥ K 6 5 2 ♦ K Q J 5 2 ♣ 6 3	N W E S	♠ Q 10 2 ♥ 9 8 7 4 3 ♦ 10 9 ♣ 8 5 4
	♠ A K 7 6 4 ♥ A J 10 ♦ 8 ♣ K Q J 7	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♠
Pass	3♠	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♥[2]	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♠ by South
Lead: ♦K

You open 1♠ and partner jumps to 3♠.

Wow. It looks like you might have a great fit. You bid 4NT and partner responds 5♥.

Partner shows 2 Aces so you bid 6♠.

South plays 6♠. West leads the ♦K.

South plays 6♠. West leads the ♦K.

Losers: ♠ 1? : ♥ 1 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 0 : Total = 2?

If trumps don't split 3-2 you will definitely go down 1, so assume they do split. You could finesse East once in ♥s, or use a ruffing finesse on West, but the cleanest approach is just to ruff two ♥s in dummy. Of course you must do this before you pull trumps.

Win the ♦A in dummy. Play the ♥Q to the ♥A and ruff the ♥10 with dummy's ♠8. Play the ♠5 to your ♠A and ruff the ♥J with dummy's ♠9.

Return to your hand with a ♣ and pull another round of trumps with your ♠K. Leaving the master trump out start playing ♣ winners. Someone may ruff with their master trump but that's the only trick they will get.

It was very bold to bid this slam and North/South were fortunate to find a distribution where it could be made.

But that would have been all for nothing if South had not found the PLAN to make it.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K 5 ♥ A 9 4 ♦ K 9 8 7 3 ♣ K 10 5	
♠ Q J 10 8 ♥ 6 5 3 ♦ Q 5 4 ♣ J 7 4		♠ A 3 2 ♥ Q J 10 7 2 ♦ J ♣ 9 8 6 2
	♠ 9 7 6 4 ♥ K 8 ♦ A 10 6 2 ♣ A Q 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♦	Pass	1♠
Pass	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥Q

With 13 points and 4 of partner's minor suit you may be tempted to say 2NT or 3♦. Both these temptations should be resisted - your first obligation is to show a 4-card Major if you have one. As poor as the suit is, you still respond 1♠.

Partner comes back with 1NT. (Hint: don't rebid the ♠s.)

Partner has 13/14 points and a balanced hand. You have 13 points and a balanced hand. How about 3NT?

South would play 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥Q.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥Q.

Winner count: ♠ 0 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 3 : Total = 7

You need two more winners and you can almost surely get them in ♦s. In fact, if the suit splits 2-2 you could actually get three more winners. But the danger here is that if they **DON'T** split 2-2 and if West happens to win the third ♦ he might lead a ♠. And that might lead to disaster!

Instead, you allow for the possibility that ♦s may not split evenly and you make sure West (the Danger hand) doesn't get the lead. Win the ♥K in dummy. Play the ♦A, (which happens to draw the ♦J from East), then play a small ♦ and finesse with the ♦9. If East can win the trick then the ♦s have split 2-2 and your other 3 ♦s are good. Most importantly though, East cannot lead a ♠ without giving you a trick with your ♠K. If the finesse works, you make 5 ♦ tricks.

Sometimes good play is just visualizing what bad thing might happen.

Here the bad thing would be for West to get the lead and play a ♠. In this case you were able to avoid the bad situation by playing a suit differently than you might have done if there were no danger.